

IN THE SENATE

SENATE CONCURRENT RESOLUTION NO. 121

BY STATE AFFAIRS COMMITTEE

A CONCURRENT RESOLUTION

STATING FINDINGS OF THE LEGISLATURE, DECLARING THAT THE EXISTING PUBLIC SCHOOL FUNDING FORMULA REQUIRES REVIEW AND MODERNIZATION, AND REQUESTING THE IDAHO STATE SUPERINTENDENT OF PUBLIC INSTRUCTION TO PRESENT DRAFT LEGISLATION TO THE LEGISLATURE THAT REVISES THE PUBLIC SCHOOL FUNDING FORMULA.

Be It Resolved by the Legislature of the State of Idaho:

WHEREAS, Section 1, Article IX of the Constitution of the State of Idaho provides that "it shall be the duty of the Legislature of Idaho to establish and maintain a general, uniform and thorough system of public, free common schools"; and

WHEREAS, the public school funding formula is the primary mechanism for distributing state appropriations to school districts and public charter schools and allocates more than \$2.5 billion dollars in state funds to local education agencies; and

WHEREAS, the current funding formula was last comprehensively revised in 1994 and was developed under educational delivery models and student needs that differ substantially from those of today, including traditional brick-and-mortar schools, rural and remote districts, small and large districts, public charter schools, virtual education programs, and blended learning models; and

WHEREAS, the Legislature recognizes that student needs vary, including students with special needs who require additional educational resources and supports; and

WHEREAS, stable and transparent funding is essential to ensuring that all Idaho students have access to high-quality educational opportunities regardless of geography, school type, or learning modality; and

WHEREAS, the Legislature finds that it is in the best interest of the state to align the public school funding formula with Idaho's vision for education and to modernize the public school funding formula to ensure it meets constitutional obligations and the evolving needs of students, staff, and communities.

NOW, THEREFORE, BE IT RESOLVED by the members of the Second Regular Session of the Sixty-eighth Idaho Legislature, the Senate and the House of Representatives concurring therein, that the Legislature declares the existing public school funding formula requires review and modernization to reflect contemporary educational practices, student needs, and work and research from the past decade.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED that the Legislature requests the State Superintendent of Public Instruction, after collaboration with the Legislature, the Governor's office, the State Board of Education, school districts, public charter schools, and stakeholder groups, to develop and present draft legislation for a revised public school funding formula, including a finan-

1 cial breakdown for each school district and public charter school, for con-
2 sideration during the First Regular Session of the Sixty-ninth Legislature.

3 BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED that recommendations for a revised public school
4 funding formula shall be developed with the following guiding considera-
5 tions:

6 (1) Constitutional duty. The funding formula should support the Leg-
7 islature in fulfilling its constitutional obligation to maintain a general,
8 uniform, and thorough system of public schools, as required by Section 1,
9 Article IX of the Constitution of the State of Idaho, and support student
10 academic growth, recognize additional needs of special student populations,
11 and consider facility, safety, and operational requirements necessary to
12 provide a thorough education;

13 (2) Accountability. The funding formula should be linked to improved
14 student outcomes;

15 (3) Predictability and stability. The funding formula should provide
16 local education agencies with the ability to reasonably forecast and budget
17 for future fiscal years, minimize significant year-to-year funding fluctua-
18 tions, and avoid abrupt funding reductions;

19 (4) Transparency. The funding formula should be clear and understand-
20 able and provide policymakers and stakeholders with meaningful insight into
21 how funds are generated, allocated, and expended;

22 (5) Student needs-based funding. The funding formula should include
23 weighted student enrollment in recognition that students require different
24 funding supports; and

25 (6) Modalities and delivery systems. The funding formula should fairly
26 and appropriately address the full range of public school modalities, in-
27 cluding rural and remote districts, small and large communities, public
28 charter schools, virtual education programs, blended learning models, and
29 other innovative instructional approaches.

30 BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED that the State Superintendent of Public Instruc-
31 tion shall present draft legislation for a revised public school funding
32 formula and an accompanying financial analysis at the fall meeting of the
33 Joint Finance-Appropriations Committee, with invitation to members of the
34 House of Representatives and Senate Education Committees, in preparation
35 for legislative consideration.

36 BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED that the Secretary of the Senate be, and she is
37 hereby authorized and directed to forward a copy of this Resolution to the
38 Idaho State Superintendent of Public Instruction and the Idaho State Board
39 of Education.